



PARADOX

A statement that seems to contradict itself but reveals a truth

1 What is it?

Paradox (PAIR-uh-doks)

A paradox is a statement that appears to contradict itself or seem impossible, but on closer inspection reveals a deeper or hidden truth.

seems contradictory + but actually makes sense

2 See it in action

Classic

"Less is more."

Literature

"I must be cruel, only to be kind." (Hamlet)

Everyday

"The only constant in life is change."

Philosophy

"I know that I know nothing."



Keep going!

Try unpacking a paradox slowly, one part at a time — the contradiction often resolves once you think about what it really means.

3 More to know

Motivational

"You have to be cruel to yourself now to be kind to yourself later."

Everyday wisdom

"The more you know, the more you realise you don't know."

FUN FACT

The "grandfather paradox" — the idea that travelling back in time to stop your grandfather meeting your grandmother would mean you were never born to travel back in time in the first place — is one of the most famous paradoxes used to argue that time travel to the past may be logically impossible.

4 Why it's used

Paradox helps: make a reader stop and think — the apparent contradiction forces deeper reflection, often revealing a genuine, thought-provoking truth once unpacked.

A paradox is different from a simple contradiction — a true paradox holds up to scrutiny and actually makes sense once you think it through, rather than just being wrong or nonsensical.



You got this!

Remember: a paradox is a whole idea or sentence, while an oxymoron is just two contradictory words stuck together.

5 Don't mix it up

PARADOX

A paradox is a whole statement or idea that seems self-contradictory but reveals a truth once unpacked — "less is more."

OXYMORON

An oxymoron is just two contradictory words placed side by side, with no deeper reasoning needed — "deafening silence," "bittersweet."

⚠ Watch out!

Don't confuse a paradox with an oxymoron — a paradox is a whole statement or idea that seems self-contradictory ("less is more"), while an oxymoron is just two contradictory words placed together ("deafening silence").

6 Quick recap

Seems contradictory

Reveals a deeper truth

Different from an oxymoron



Think about...

Famous quotes are a great place to spot paradoxes — writers and philosophers use them to make you pause and think.